LITTLE LANTERN · FREE

The 6pm Sheet

Ten things to say when everyone has had enough. Stick it on the fridge. For children aged 4 to 6.

WHEN THEY WON'T SAY SORRY

"You don't have to feel sorry yet. You just have to start."

Forcing the word teaches obedience. This gives them a way in while the feeling catches up.

WHEN SORRY DOESN'T STICK

"Sorry is only one word. Try three: what I did, how you feel, what I'll do."

"I knocked your tower over. You worked hard on it. Can I help you rebuild it?"

WHEN WAITING IS UNBEARABLE

"How many more turns until you?"

The waiting isn't the problem — not knowing how long is. A number can be held. A forever can't.

MID-MELTDOWN

"Hand on your tummy. In for four... and out for six."

Do it with them, not at them. It only works if you're breathing too.

IN THE SHOP

"You really wanted it. That's a horrible feeling, and I'm not cross with you for having it."

Name the feeling, then hold the line. In that order. Don't explain why — mid-feeling, reasons sound like negotiation.

WHEN THEY HIDE BEHIND YOUR LEG

"If the words won't come today, a wave is a whole hello. That counts."

Always give a lower rung. And never apologise for their shyness in front of them.

WHEN YOU'RE ON THE PHONE

"Put your hand on my arm and wait. I'll squeeze it so you know I felt it."

Agree the signal first. Then come fast the first few times or the system dies.

WHEN THE ROOM DEFEATS EVERYONE

"Not all of it. Just the blue things. Go."

"Tidy your room" is far too big for a five-year-old to picture. One category at a time.

WHEN THEY NEED TO REFUSE SOMETHING

"Not right now, but maybe after."

Children need a kind no as much as a yes. Never teach that refusing is unkind — that one isn't safe.

WHEN THEY'RE BURSTING TO SPEAK

"Hold your idea. Squeeze it in your hand so it can't escape. I'll ask you in a minute."

They genuinely believe the thought will vanish. Give it somewhere to live — then actually ask.

One rule worth more than all ten: after you ask a question, stop talking and count to three. Children need the silence to answer it. Most of us fill it.

There are fifty more of these

This is ten cards out of **The Off-Screen Pack** — sixty two-minute lessons you can do with your child without a screen. Thirty on letters and numbers, thirty on kindness. Every one has the words to say, what to do, and what to do when it goes wrong.

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General guidance for everyday parenting, not clinical or educational advice. If you have concerns about your child's speech, hearing, learning or behaviour, speak to your GP, health visitor or teacher.